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By Mathieu Pollet · Oct 16, 2026, 7:43 PM · View in your browser

BRUSSELS — The European Union is under pressure to keep Ukrainian troops fully online after Elon Musk's Starlink was restricted amid volatile U.S. support for Kyiv.

"It was a very dangerous and unpleasant surprise," Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy told reporters after EU leaders met in Brussels, referring to Starlink speed limitations experienced by military troops in recent days. "We were using Starlink to intercept jet-powered Shaheds [combat drones] that are attacking our civilian infrastructure and killing our families … When the speed limits were lowered, we became incapable of shooting [them] down."

Ukraine has long relied critically on Musk's satellite constellation for wartime efforts. Reuters reported Friday that the order to slow Ukraine's military-grade Starshield service came from the White House, days after Washington pressed Kyiv to halt strikes on Russian refineries, amid soaring energy prices and ahead of November's midterm elections.

"It is unacceptable for Ukraine's defense — and therefore Europe's security — to depend on the goodwill of a single American billionaire or on Donald Trump's decisions," French centrist Member of the European Parliament Christophe Grudler told POLITICO.

Ahead of Thursday's high-level meeting, European lawmakers had been calling on the EU executive to fast-track Kyiv's access to satellite capabilities already pooled under the bloc's Govsatcom program — which gives participating governments secure communications capabilities.

Negotiations between the EU executive and Ukraine over this access have been ongoing since March, with no breakthrough. Norway and Iceland secured such an agreement earlier this year.

"What I don't understand is why the European Commission and the Member States have not done everything possible to quickly reach an agreement that would allow Ukraine to benefit from it," added Christophe Grudler, who wrote to EU leaders.

He also called on them to speed up work on IRIS² — the EU's in-house, planned satellite network and full-fledged match to Starlink, which is only expected to come online in 2030.

Commission spokesperson Thomas Regnier confirmed in a statement that it is "currently in talks with Ukraine to fully associate" the country with the EU's Govsatcom program. "The war in Ukraine shows that our security also depends on space. And the EU has been doing quite a lot. We are ready to support Ukraine where we can support Ukraine," he added.

Calls to crack down on dependence on foreign providers and boost alternatives to Starlink also come at a time when legislators are negotiating a series of laws that could tame Musk's ambitions in Europe.

"Ukraine's dependence on Starlink highlights the vulnerability of European defence systems that rely on U.S. technology, Another reminder that Europe must reduce its dangerous technological dependencies — ASAP," center-right Finnish lawmaker Aura Salla said on social media.

Policymakers across Europe have been joining forces to curb Starlink's dominance in low-Earth orbit, where satellites fly close to Earth to deliver faster connections.

"As legislators, we must ensure that European operators are well positioned in the market and limit the dominance of foreign players," German center-left lawmaker Matthias Ecke said. In Brussels, lawmakers, including Ecke, are backing European telcos gunning for prized satellite frequencies, currently licensed to U.S. operators until next year and eyed by Starlink.

Meanwhile, Zelenskyy said Ukraine was working bilaterally with EU countries to secure more capabilities, citing France. He also expressed hopes that Starlink restrictions could be lifted. "My partners told me there were signals from the White House that they would return these capabilities."

SpaceX — Starlink's parent company — didn't respond to POLITICO's request for comment.

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